

On the Perfection of Grace and Desire in the Soul

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In the ever-complexifying world of modernity, the individual is caught between a multiplicity of discursive processes that form incommensurate and contradictory notions of the self, of desire, and of one's relationship to the broader culture. The discontent is no longer a marginalized position of a small minority but a permanent condition of every individual. St. Augustine of Hippo occupied a similar period, where competing worldviews sought for adherents to mold into their image and to subsequently influence society to reproduce their political visions. But Augustine's capacity to dramatize his own life within the context of a larger drama of the society he lived in provides a unique approach to address the common good.

Turning away from his Manichaean youth he found, under the influence of figures like Jerome and Ambrose, an alternative account of the person and its relationship to God, and this subsequently would lead Augustine to wage a series of definitive debates that continue to influence the church over fifteen-hundred years later. In it, he opposes the pagan view of the self as a tragic theatre for God and instead supplements the confession as a movement of repentance towards the origin of good; a God whose personal care for humanity reflects his own relational and self-giving nature in a movement of love which conditions and determines the souls that he calls back to himself. In this essay, I will argue that Augustine's encounter with the triune God leads him to articulate a theory of the self as one which undergoes a formative process where one's psychology is reordered in God's image and which defines the political mission and orientation of the church as one which bears witness to the reality of the world made by the triune God out of love.

In his *Confessions*, Augustine begins with an account of the acquisition of language as his first entry into the economy of desire. He states, as an infant, that he “threw his limbs about and uttered sounds, signs resembling my wishes, the small number of signs of which I was capable but such signs as lay in my power to use: for there was no real resemblance.”¹ Even throughout infancy, as we see, Augustine recognizes the utilization of signs as markers which point beyond themselves though, at the early stage of development, the infants ability to communicate is aleatory, as he states, “By groans and various sounds and various movements of parts of my body I would endeavor to express the intentions of my heart to persuade people to bow to my will.”² However, this aleatory stage marks the relationship between the self’s desire and its dependence upon others, which points towards an ultimate dependence upon God, as Augustine states, “but it was not my mother or my nurses who made any decision to fill their breasts, but you who through them gave me infant food, in accordance with your ordinance and the riches which are distributed deep in the natural order.”³ This double signification of signs towards objects which themselves ultimately point towards the transcendent God is a constant theme throughout Augustine’s writings, finding its explicit statement in *De Doctrina Christiana* but also finding its significance in his work on the trinity and his social commentary. The typological relationship of things as not properly belonging to themselves but pointing beyond themselves and ultimately towards a relational capacity for the soul to order its desires towards God as the proper basis for its existence also finds its seeds within infantile desire and forms the basis of Augustine’s

¹ Augustine, *Confessions*, (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991), 7.

² Ibid., 10.

³ Ibid., 6.

typological and semiotic. However, before fully exploring the nature of typology in Augustine's account of desire, further elucidation of infant language acquisition will be helpful.

Augustine further elaborates on the aleatory experimentation of the infant and concludes that the texturing of the psyche in the memory and will emerges from this process. He states, "the natural vocabulary of all races, and are made with the face and the inclination of the eyes and the movements of other parts of the boy... which indicates whether the mind's inward sentiments are to seek and possess or to reject and avoid".⁴ In this way, the infant's experimentations start to coalesce into the recognition that the Other to whom the signification is directed is also a desiring body and whose reactions start to introduce the infant into sociality as the mouth becomes organized as the site of articulation as opposed to the rest of the body, as Augustine states, "I learnt to articulate my wishes by training my mouth to use these signs... and entered more deeply into the stormy society of human life."⁵ Augustine suggests here that as the infant moves away from using the whole body for signifying desire and towards its convergence on the mouth as the primary site for articulation that the infant becomes more immersed in pre-established linkages of language inhabited by culture and society. This interplay between the self and other in language acquisition starts to provide the conditioning texture of the memory, as Augustine recounts, "My grasp made use of memory: when people gave a name to an object... I would see and retain the fact that that object received..."⁶ which further elucidates how the

⁴ Ibid., 11.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Ibid., 10-11

primary emergence into language creates a discursive formation of desire as it produces the topology of relations which metonymically organize language into sensible propositions.

Augustine further reflects on the differences of various signifying regimes as he recounts the differences he found in the differing languages he learned throughout his childhood. When noting the differences his acquisition of Latin and Greek, he notes that “he was repellant” and that he imagines “Greek boys feel the same about Virgil when they are forced to learn him in the way that [Augustine] learnt Homer.”⁷ He infers from this experience that it “sufficiently illuminates the truth that free curiosity has greater power to stimulate learning than rigorous coercion.”⁸ This begins his polemic against the nature of the City of Man and signals Augustine’s belief that the original nature of humanity is grounded in goodness with discipline being a secondary consequence of the fall. Nevertheless, God abounds in his goodness such that Augustine concludes, “Your laws have the power to temper bitter experiences in a constructive way, recalling us to yourself from the pestilential life of easy comforts which have taken us away from you.”⁹ Even though creativity is our original position which allows us to initially acquire language, the formation of desire brings us further away from this peaceful acquisition of knowledge, which then requires the disciplinary apparatus of the Roman state as the incommensurate conflict of wills conditioned by the City of Man requires the adjudication of the state apparatus – nevertheless, Augustine holds to the view that the allowance of such a deviation nevertheless bears witness to God’s providential ordering of history.

⁷ Ibid., 17.

⁸ Ibid.

⁹ Ibid.

This leads Augustine to make a distinction in the belief of a providentially ordered history versus the capriciousness of the pagan gods. He states that Homer had “attribute[d] divine sanction to vicious acts, which had the result that immorality was no longer counted immorality” leading those formed by such a language to believe that their actions were after “the example not of abandoned men but of the gods in heaven.”¹⁰ Here, we see Augustine not only continue his critique of the pagan gods, but also demonstrate the desire-formative element in language whereby the typologies and relations of signs inherited by language form the psychology and desires of the language user. The acquisition of this desire requires the further supplement of violence to be inundated into the self as Augustine points out that the “wine of error” was poured out by “drunken teachers” and that “[i]f we failed to drink, we were caned and could not appeal to any sober judge.”¹¹ Thus, the disoriented desires of the teachers were redoubled on the students through an act of force that contradicts the more original state of creativity. Augustine recounts “I learnt this text with pleasure and took delight in it, wretch that I was.”¹² As Augustine recounts the nature of his language acquisition, he stresses the continued formation of desire which reproduces the violence of the state. Augustine concludes by recognizing that such a formation had led him to “[seek] pleasure, sublimity, and truth not in God but in his creatures, in myself and other create beings” and that, instead, he ends by declaring that his inborn gifts “will increase and be perfected, and I will be with you since it was your gift to me that I exist.”¹³

¹⁰ Ibid., 18.

¹¹ Ibid., 19.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Ibid., 22-23.

It is here that we can turn from Augustine's self-reflection on his language acquisition process to his broader conception of the semiotic system. The primary dichotomies that Augustine uses are the sign/thing dichotomy and the use/enjoy dichotomy. Towards the former, he states, "All teaching is either about things or signs; but things are learned about through signs."¹⁴ It is interesting to note at this juncture the ontological difference between things and signs gives a deeper priority of being to things, but that the anchor which allows us to render things sensible persists within signs. Augustine makes it explicit that language is used "for the sake of signifying something" alone but that we must "bear in mind all the time that what has to be considered about things is that they are, not that they signify something else besides themselves."¹⁵ This establishes that as confused and incommensurate as the world of signification may be, that it should be confused with thinking that the order of being is as equally confused and incommensurate – instead, he signals that similar to how our immersion into language confuses the order of our desires, that it is not desire itself which misunderstands the value of things, but the incoherence as represented in the order of signs. Therefore, Augustine is re-iterating here the crucial link between language and desire.

In the second dichotomy, that of use/enjoy, he states, "Things that are to be enjoyed make us happy; things which are to be used help us on our way to happiness..."¹⁶ This again suggests that our desire, which is oriented towards things, should be oriented ultimately towards those things that guarantee our happiness as objects of enjoyment and that we should not confuse these

¹⁴ Augustine, *De Doctrina Christiana* (New York: New City Press, 1996), 110.

¹⁵ Ibid.

¹⁶ Ibid.

ultimate guarantors of happiness with those things which are meant to be used as “crutches and props for reaching the things that will make us happy, and enabling us to keep them.”¹⁷

Ultimately, God alone is to be enjoyed and all other things are to be used in order to fully comprehend how such things participate in the larger order of being, which itself is fully within God such that to use a thing to love God is to desire that thing’s most appropriate end, as Augustine states, “...because our making use of things is directed to the end of enjoying God’s goodness...”¹⁸ This is made sensible by the fact that God “does not enjoy us, but makes use of us” which Augustine explains stating, “Because he is good, after all, we simply are; and insofar as we are, we are good.”¹⁹ In this sense, Augustine agrees with the Platonists that evil is a privation of the good and, more specifically, privation of the appropriate ordering of things such that they most fully subsist within God.

This subsistence which finds itself fuller as it finds itself in God is articulated by Augustine through the right order of love. Augustine recites the Great Commandment stating, “But when it says, *You shall love your neighbor as yourself*, love of yourself by yourself is being simultaneously included.”²⁰ This radical immanence is possible because of Augustine’s commitment to the privation theory of evil, but the unique valence that it receives here is that because things final teleological end most appropriate belongs to God, who alone consists in the fullness of being, the right ordering of things does not diminish certain potentialities in favor of

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ Ibid., 126.

¹⁹ Ibid.

²⁰ Ibid., 122.

others but, because the divine mind is inexhaustible, more fully expresses the potentialities which allow it to subsist. Therefore, Augustine can say, “And if God is to be loved more than any human being, we all ought to love God more than ourselves.”²¹

Thus, the ontological dichotomy in the realm of things mirrors the dichotomy within realm of signification, though imperfectly, yet again suggesting the difficulty of language’s capacity to properly mirror the ontological order of things. There resonates within this dual ordering the Platonic distinction between being and becoming through which the multiplicity of temporally bounded realities find their identity within an order of Being which stabilizes them through the simplicity of the form of the good – Augustine says as much, as well, noting that of all things, “those alone are to be enjoyed... as being eternal and unchanging, while the rest are to be used, in order that we may come at last to the enjoyment of the former sort.”²² However, for Augustine, the ultimate object of enjoyment to which all our signification converges upon is the personal God which, as we shall see when discussing the account of mystical ascent, is the one who personally grounds the care of the self. Augustine states, “Yes, a great thing indeed is man, made *to the image and likeness of God*... not insofar as he is enclosed in a mortal body, but insofar as he takes precedence over the animals in the dignity of a rational soul.”²³ While it may seem, then, that our embodiment is a mere accidental feature of our dignity, nevertheless, as will be explored near the end, it is due to Augustine’s understanding of the soul bounded in a body

²¹ Ibid.

²² Ibid., 110.

²³ Ibid.

which reflects not only the eternal nature of God, but God's own embodiment within an eschatological horizon which exemplifies his relational character.

Nevertheless, despite the role of the body in redemptive history, and the *imago dei* to which such a souled body represents, Augustine warns us regarding placing our eschatological hopes on other individuals stating, "...if a thing is to be loved for its own sake, it means that it constitutes the life of bliss... *Cursed, however, is the one who places his hopes in man.*"²⁴ Such human *qua* human relating, then, cannot constitute the final horizon of our happiness. This simultaneously applies to self-love as Augustine explains "their enjoyment of themselves is to some extent defective, because they are better when they cleave to the unchangeable good and are tightly bound to it, than when they release themselves from it to cling even to themselves."²⁵ Thus, such self-love is self-defeating as the object of love is conditioned by time and, thus, cannot sustain the totality of its possibilities simultaneously but can only refer to itself as it is conditioned by a series of unforeseen forces which express only partial potentialities. When the object of our final enjoyment is God, however, then our use of ourselves finds its proper teleological orientation within an eschatological hope which sustains the noumenal purity of all its possibilities unified.

This is also why, when commenting on the *summary of the law*, Augustine points out that there is no need for a commandment to love the body or the self. He accounts for this by establishing a chain of being between things which are to be used and things which are to be loved stating "not all things, however, which are to be used are also to be loved, but only those

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid.

which can be related to God together with ourselves in a kind of social companionship”²⁶ further exemplifying the relational quality of Augustinian love and the priority of the person over and against a process which nullifies the distinction between person and act, as Augustine reminds us, “the martyrs did not love the crimes their persecutors were committing against them.”²⁷

These four possible objects of love, then, are follows, as Augustine recounts, “one which is above us [God and the angels], the second which we are ourselves, the third which is on a level with us, the fourth which is beneath us [animals and other lower creatures]. . .”²⁸ Of these, Augustine comments that there need be no commandment to love the second and last.

This ordering of higher and lower desires stems from the ontological differences related to these various objects. Augustine states that all people, even those who fall away from truth, “there [still] remains in them love of self and love of one’s own body”.²⁹ However, such love of self, according to Augustine stems from the fact that “the human spirit” which “thinks it has something great if it can lord it over its fellows” which he believes is “a simple case of iniquity, because such a spirit is wanting to be served by what is beneath it”³⁰ – namely, that the bodily self is allowing his appetites to ignore the fact that the other is a souled, or rational, body. We see here, then, that the process of desire finds its appropriate culmination in the mutual recognition and reconciliation of two bodies as both exemplifying a rational nature, and thus producing a

²⁶ Ibid., 119.

²⁷ Ibid.

²⁸ Ibid.

²⁹ Ibid.

³⁰ Ibid.

normative demand on one another to be treated not merely as an object of one another's appetites but appropriately as an object of love.

Nevertheless, Augustine also is quick to remind us that such mutual recognition is not through a disembodied medium, as he states, nobody would "prefer to do without a body altogether" but that such a mistaken view stems from the misuse of the body due to our inherent fragility, and that our real desire would be for a body "that does not decay and that is as fleet and swift as a bird".³¹ However, while this desire signals the appropriate object of our desire within our eschatological horizon, it nonetheless cannot be achieved on this side of eternity, hence producing the rationality of the practice of virtue. Augustine states that those who are "apparently harrying their bodies with self-restraint and hard toil, if they are doing this in the right manner... are extinguishing the lusts that make bad use of the body, that is to say the habits and tendencies of the soul to seek enjoyment in inferior things."³² In this way, Augustine firmly establishes the body as part of the providential order of being whose teleological orientation properly belongs to the good, but of which must undergo a process in to "thereby make it subject to the spirit, as the natural order of things requires"³³ so that it is not that the spirit is contrary to the body, but occupies a different logic or, rather, "that the spirit [does not] resist[] the flesh out of hatred, but out of principle, because it wishes what it loves all the more to be subordinate to the better."³⁴ Since it is better to be both a soul and a body (or, in other words, a body with

³¹ Ibid., 120.

³² Ibid.

³³ Ibid.

³⁴ Ibid., 121.

reason), then it is for the sake of mutual participation in the form of the person to which the virtues are oriented. However, such orientation necessarily requires the mutual assent and participation in language, and so such rationally ordered desires already presupposes communication which render the self vulnerable to the process of miscommunication which can overturn the ordering of the passions and lead the self to descend back into concupiscence. Nevertheless, as Augustine discovered, there remains within the soul the imprint of the divine nature which reminds the individual of his true nature.

In accounting for the faculty of memory, Augustine discovers that within the human mind is a knowledge which exceeds itself and provides the determining ground for the cultivation of the moral life through a power in “the heart [which] is arouse in the love of [God’s] mercy and the sweetness of your grace by which every weak person is given power, while dependence on grace produces awareness of one’s own weakness.”³⁵ Hence the mind finds within itself a power that must properly belong there and yet exceeds the self so that the self is inter-dependent on something that is not itself. Here, Augustine also performs a statement of intent of the whole work, stating, “So as I make my confession, they wish to learn about my inner self, where they cannot penetrate with eye or ear or mind.”³⁶

Such articulation of the inner self, then, is not amenable to rational articulation without a prior encounter with the truth of God’s goodness, as Augustine explains, “[t]he love which makes them good people tells them that I am not lying in confessing about myself, and the love in them

³⁵ Augustine, *Confessions*, 180.

³⁶ *Ibid.*, 181.

believes me.”³⁷ Thus, the role of confession belongs to the community of believers who are constituted by the shared recognition of the love that persists in the inner self but is habitually forgotten by the order of this world. Memory, for Augustine, preserves much more about ourselves than any particular moment can bear witness to, as he explains, “[m]emory preserves in distinct particulars and general categories all the perceptions which have penetrated, each by its own route of entry.”³⁸ It is through memory that the self is capable of recalling more than it immediately is, but ascertaining all the encounters and relations which have brought it to that point and becomes the basis for how the self is capable of recognizing within the course of its life the work of divine providence in constituting it as it is – Augustine states, “I say these words to myself and, as I speak, there are present images of everything I am speaking of, drawn out of the same treasure-house of memory.”³⁹ This treasure-house which far exceeds the self within the self where one “[can] see inwardly with dimensions just as great as if [they] were actually looking at them outside [their] mind”⁴⁰ is where one discovers in their bodily sense something “imprinted on [their] mind.”⁴¹ It is this recollecting power of memory which binds together the disparate moments of life into the totality of the self which is “characterized by diversity, by life of many forms, utterly immeasurable.”⁴² Yet it is in the same space that one recollects their disparate moments that Augustine tells us one is able to find God stating, “My true good and

³⁷ Ibid., 181.

³⁸ Ibid., 186.

³⁹ Ibid., 187.

⁴⁰ Ibid.

⁴¹ Ibid., 187.

⁴² Ibid., 194.

gentle source of reassurance, where shall I find you? If I find you outside my memory, I am not mindful of you. And how shall I find you if I am not mindful of you.”⁴³

It is through this image that Augustine concludes one sees the inner-trinitarian life at work. But, as he states, “If we ask what kind of mirror this might be, the thought occurs to us that the only thing ever seen in a mirror is an image.”⁴⁴ It is towards this image that Augustine cites Paul stating, “So, *we are being transformed*” and continues, “we are being changed from one form to form, and are passing from a blurred form a clear one.”⁴⁵ Though the course of time has disordered the image of God, nevertheless it is this form to which the self participates in transformation as it ascends back to its original glory in the image of God, as Augustine states, “that the good of such a desirable transformation is conferred on us by God’s grace.”⁴⁶ Just as Augustine’s own life story begins with the confused experience of an infant and continues towards further clarification toward the hope that the culmination of his experiences will bear witness to the work of providence throughout his own life, so too will the work of God find its culmination in the expression of His image in the life of every Christian.

This becomes, for Augustine, the distinguishing line between the earthly hope of the Roman state and the transformative hope of the Christian. Augustine recounts the nature of the Roman cult stating, “Rather the gods themselves, by imperious command and virtually by extortion, cause the Romans to put on those shows in ritual performances consecrated to their

⁴³ Ibid., 195.

⁴⁴ Augustine, *De Trinitate* (New York, New City Press, 1991) 520.

⁴⁵ Ibid., 521.

⁴⁶ Ibid., 522.

honor...”⁴⁷ and he continues, “For it was at a time when the plague was running rampant that, by the authority of the pontiffs, theatrical shows were first instituted by Rome.”⁴⁸ For the Romans, their sufferings had become the tragic theatre for the gods signaling the moral decay of their cultural imagination at large. Augustine notes that the Greeks were at least more consistent as “[t]hey saw that to discredit not only human beings but even the gods themselves” as “acceptable and pleasing to [them].”⁴⁹ Thus, the Greek culture, which had for Augustine represented the height of pagan learning, had more consistently thought out the depravity of their own culture projecting their own degradation to the image of their highest value.

How different, then, is a God who listens to the confession of his people and of whom Augustine prays, “I call upon you, my God, my mercy.”⁵⁰ Rather than the capricious gods for whom human life is a theatre, Augustine prays to his God, “when I forgot you, you did not forget me”⁵¹ signifying a God of faithfulness to the promises and attentive to his adherents. In regards to the goodness of matter, Augustine recognizes that it had no merit before God since, “[i]t would not exist unless you had made it” and that God’s making it, “Its formlessness could not be pleasing to you unless it were made light not by merely existing but by contemplating the source of light and adhering to it.”⁵² This suggests both that the creation of the physical world is not only a contingent event in relation to God, but emerges out of his self-reflexive nature, and that

⁴⁷ Augustine, *De Civitate Dei Books 1-10* (New York: New City Press, 2012), 43.

⁴⁸ *Ibid.*, 44.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, 45.

⁵⁰ Augustine, *Confessions*, 273.

⁵¹ *Ibid.*

⁵² *Ibid.*, 275.

its' subsistence stems from a continued faithfulness to preserve it into being, not from necessity, "but from the fullness of [God's] goodness, imposing control and converting it to receive form—but not as if the result brought you fulfilment of delight."⁵³ Augustine reiterates here that God alone is to be enjoyed as the sole source of all goodness and, physical matter, of which we partly persist, persists precisely within this goodness.

To conclude, this goodness of creation in eschatological history is where the confessing self subsists. As Augustine recognizes, he perceives the goodness of creation as follows; "Here in an enigmatic image I discern the Trinity, which you are, my God."⁵⁴ Such a recognition of God emerges from the inward turn whereby an encounter with God led Augustine to realize that the ground of his own self-knowledge was his relatedness to the Trinity and towards whom he was led towards pursuing conforming his mind and body through the training of virtue to understand and enjoy more fully and, in turn, to allow himself to be used towards his own most appropriate end, as Augustine states, "For there are neither languages nor discourses in which [God's messengers] are not hear."⁵⁵ This indwelling of the heavenly in the earthly is what allows Augustine to dynamically sustain the order of being without privation, but one which continually becomes more itself as the divine more fully reveals itself such that the "things of which the knowledge is fixed and determined without evolving with the generations, such as the lights of wisdom and knowledge" can nonetheless continue to grow in signification since "their

⁵³ Ibid.

⁵⁴ Ibid., 276.

⁵⁵ Ibid., 288.

embodiments in the physical realm are both many and varied.”⁵⁶ For Augustine, there is no limit to the actualizations of these potentials since “All things are beautiful because you made them, but you who made everything are inexpressibly more beautiful.”⁵⁷ God’s inexhaustibility does not diminish what can be made actual, but allows the actual to far exceed itself within the life of the church as the world is ordered more perfectly towards its creator. Regarding physical things, the endless play of signification given to them brings them more fully alive such that Augustine can state “the interpretation that I now give to reptiles and birds” are made more fully themselves through their “subjection to corporeal sacraments [which] do not make further progress unless in the spiritual realm their soul comes to live on another level and, subsequent to the words of initiation, looks towards their perfection.”⁵⁸ And if such perfection is possible for the lowest of creatures, how much more will the peaks of perfection be reached in the creature who bears His image for, as Augustine states in the beginning of the *Confessions*, “You stir man to take pleasure in praising you, because you have made us for yourself, and our heart is restless until it rests in you.”⁵⁹

⁵⁶ Ibid., 289.

⁵⁷ Ibid.

⁵⁸ Ibid., 289.

⁵⁹ Ibid., 3.